

Word family: **before / beforehand**

Base word: before

Part of speech: preposition, conjunction, adverb

Related forms / useful extensions:

before — 在.....之前；以前；早於

beforehand — 事先；預先

the day before — 前一天

before long — 不久之後

before too long — 過不了多久

before then — 在那之前

before that — 在那之前

never before — 從未有過；以前從未

once before — 以前曾經一次

the night before — 前一晚

before doing something — 做某事之前

before someone does something — 在某人做某事之前

Meaning in this passage

> **Before meeting him**, I used to think studying meant memorising facts and repeating them in exams.

Here, **before** means:

earlier than a particular event or action in time — 在.....之前

The speaker means that this was their view **before they met Mr Chan**.

中文翻譯：

在**認識他之前**，我一直以為讀書就是背誦資料，然後在考試中重複寫出來。

So here:

before meeting him = 在認識他之前

1. **before + noun / event — 在.....之前**

This is the core meaning used in your passage.

Practice 1 — original sentence

> **Before meeting him**, I used to think studying meant memorising facts.

在**認識他之前**，我一直以為讀書就是背資料。

Practice 2

> We spoke **before the meeting**.

我們在**會議之前**談過。

Practice 3

> Finish your homework **before dinner**.

在**晚飯前**完成你的功課。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****before = 在某個時間、事件或活動發生之前****

2. **before + -ing — 在做某事之前**

A very common grammar pattern.

Practice 1

> Wash your hands **before eating**.

****吃東西前**先洗手。**

Practice 2

> Think carefully **before answering**.

****回答之前**先仔細想一想。**

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****before + -ing = 在做某個動作之前****

3. **before + clause — 在.....之前**

Practice 1

> Call me ****before you leave****.

你****離開之前****打電話給我。

Practice 2

> Check everything ****before the lesson starts****.

在****課堂開始之前****檢查所有東西。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****before + clause = 在另一件事發生之前****

4. ****before (adverb : 以前 ; 之前) — 以前 ; 之前****

Practice 1

> I've seen this film ****before****.

我****以前****看過這部電影。

Practice 2

> Have we met ****before****?

我們****以前****見過嗎？

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****before = 在現在或另一個參考時間之前的某個時候****

5. ****never before — 從未有過 ; 以前從未****

Practice 1

> I had ****never seen anything like it before****.

我****以前從未見過****這樣的東西。

Practice 2

> The city had ****never before experienced**** such heavy rain.

這座城市****以前從未經歷過****這麼大的雨。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****never before = 在此之前一次也沒有****

6. ****once / twice before — 以前曾經一次 / 兩次****

Practice 1

> I'd met him ****once before****.

我****以前見過他一次****。

Practice 2

> She had visited the city ****twice before****.

她****以前去過那個城市兩次****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****once/twice before = 在此之前曾經發生過一次 / 兩次****

7. ****the day / night / week before — 前一天 / 前一晚 / 前一週****

Practice 1

> I saw him ****the day before****.

我在****前一天****見過他。

Practice 2

> She had prepared everything ****the night before****.

她在****前一晚****已經準備好一切。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****the X before = 某個參考時間之前的那一天 / 晚上 / 星期等****

8. **before that / before then — 在那之前**

Practice 1

> I had never heard of him **before that**.

在**那之前**，我從未聽過他。

Practice 2

> We need to finish it **before then**.

我們要在**那之前**完成。

MCQ-ready definition:

before that/then = 在剛才提到的那個時間之前

9. **before long — 不久之後**

A fixed expression whose meaning may surprise learners.

Practice 1

> **Before long**, everyone was laughing.

不久之後，大家都笑了起來。

Practice 2

> The rain stopped, and **before long** the sun came out.

雨停了，**沒過多久**太陽就出來了。

MCQ-ready definition:

before long = 過不了多久；很快

Important: it does **not** mean 「很久以前」.

10. **before too long — 過不了多久**

Practice 1

> You'll feel better **before too long**.

你**過不了多久**就會好一點。

Practice 2

> We should hear from them **before too long**.

我們應該**不用多久**就會收到他們的消息。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****before too long = 在不太久之後；很快****

11. ****beforehand — 事先；預先****

A useful related form.

Practice 1

> Please let me know ****beforehand****.

請****事先****告訴我。

Practice 2

> We had prepared everything ****beforehand****.

我們已經****預先****準備好一切。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****beforehand = 在某件事發生之前，預先****

12. ****before someone — 早於某人；比某人先****

Practice 1

> She arrived ****before me****.

她****比我先到****。

Practice 2

> He finished the test **before everyone else**.

他**比其他所有人更早**完成測驗。

MCQ-ready definition:

before someone = 在時間或次序上早於某人

13. **before something in order / sequence** — 在.....前面

Not always purely temporal.

Practice 1

> B comes **before C** in the alphabet.

字母表中 B 排在 C **前面**。

Practice 2

> Your name comes **before mine** on the list.

你的名字在名單上排在**我的前面**。

MCQ-ready definition:

before = 在排列、次序或位置上較前

14. **put X before Y** — 把 X 放在 Y 之前；優先考慮 X

A figurative priority sense.

Practice 1

> She always **puts her family before work**.

她總是把**家庭放在工作之前**。

Practice 2

> Safety should come **before convenience**.

****安全應優先於方便**。**

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****put X before Y / X comes before Y = 認為 X 比 Y 更重要、應優先處理****

15. ****appear / come before a court or committee — 出席法庭 / 委員會****

A formal institutional sense.

Practice 1

> He was asked to ****appear before the court****.

他被要求****出庭****。

Practice 2

> The witness came ****before the committee****.

證人到場****向委員會作供 / 出席委員會****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****before a court/committee = 在法庭、委員會等正式機構面前出席或接受審查****

16. ****lay / place something before someone — 把某事呈交某人考慮****

Formal.

Practice 1

> The proposal was ****placed before the board****.

提案被****提交董事會審議****。

Practice 2

> The evidence was ****laid before the court****.

證據被****呈交法庭****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****place/lay something before someone = 正式把某事提交給某人或機構考慮、審查****

Important distinction 1: **before vs ago**

Very important.

before

needs a reference point:

> I had seen him before.

我以前見過他。

ago

counts backward from now:

> I saw him two years ago.

我兩年前見過他。

Do not say:

> two years before

unless another past reference point is given.

Important distinction 2: **before vs earlier**

before

links one event/time to another.

earlier

means at an earlier time and can stand more independently.

> I arrived before him.

我比他早到。

> I arrived earlier.

我早一點到了。

Important distinction 3: ****before vs previously****

****before****

ordinary and conversational.

****previously****

more formal:

= at an earlier time.

> I've seen this before.

我以前看過這個。

> The building was previously used as a school.

這座建築以前曾用作學校。

Important distinction 4: ****before vs by****

This is a major grammar distinction.

****before Friday****

= earlier than Friday.

****by Friday****

= no later than Friday.

> Finish it before Friday.

要在星期五之前完成。

> Finish it by Friday.

最遲星期五完成。

****By**** includes Friday; ****before**** normally does not.

Important distinction 5: ****before vs until****

****before****

focuses on something happening earlier than another point.

****until****

focuses on continuation up to a point.

> Leave before six.

六點前離開。

> Stay until six.

留到六點。

Important distinction 6: ****before doing vs before you do****

Both are correct:

> Think before ****speaking****.

> Think before ****you speak****.

The first is more compact; the second explicitly names the subject.

Important distinction 7: ****before = time vs before = order****

Time

> before dinner

晚飯前

Sequence

> A comes before B.

A 排在 B 前面。

These are related but should be recognized separately.

Important distinction 8: **before = earlier vs before = priority**

Temporal

> She arrived before me.

她比我先到。

Priority

> Family comes before work.

家庭比工作優先。

The priority sense is metaphorical.

Important distinction 9: **before long vs long before**

These are almost opposites.

before long

= 不久之後

> Before long, he relaxed.

不久後，他放鬆了。

long before

= 早在很久之前

> This happened long before I was born.

這件事早在我出生很久以前便發生了。

Very important learner trap.

Important distinction 10: ****beforehand vs before****

****before****

usually relates directly to another noun/clause/event:

> before the meeting

****beforehand****

stands alone more naturally:

> Tell me beforehand.

事先告訴我。

So:

> before the meeting 

> beforehand the meeting 

Important distinction 11: ****the day before vs the previous day****

These are equivalent in many contexts:

> the day before

前一天

> the previous day

前一天

But ****the day before**** often sounds more conversational.

Important distinction 12: ****before someone vs in front of someone****

****before someone****

can mean earlier than them, or formally in their presence.

in front of someone

physical position.

> I arrived before him.

我比他早到。

> I stood in front of him.

我站在他前面。

Do not confuse temporal/order **before** with physical **in front of**.

Family-extension note

Before is highly useful because it functions across several grammatical roles while keeping a broadly stable core:

earlier than a reference point

Its main branches are:

1. **time**

- * before dinner
- * before meeting him
- * before you leave

2. **earlier experience**

- * I've seen it before
- * never before

3. **relative time expressions**

- * the day before
- * before then
- * beforehand

4. **sequence/order**

* A comes before B

5. **priority**

* family before work

6. **formal presence/submission**

* appear before a court

* place a proposal before the board

7. **fixed expressions**

* before long

* before too long

The important learner challenge is less about radically different dictionary senses and more about **grammar role + idiomatic meaning**, especially **before long**, **by vs before**, and **before vs ago**.

Master comparison

Form / expression	Traditional Chinese	Core idea
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before + noun	在.....之前	earlier than event
before + -ing	做.....之前	earlier than action
before + clause	在.....之前	earlier than clause event
before (adverb)	以前；之前	earlier time
never before	從未有過	not previously
once before	以前一次	previous occurrence
the day before	前一天	previous day
the night before	前一晚	previous night
before that/then	在那之前	prior reference point
before long	不久之後	soon
before too long	過不了多久	soon
beforehand	事先；預先	in advance
before someone	比某人早	earlier than person
A before B	A 在 B 前	sequence
put X before Y	X 優先於 Y	priority
appear before a court	出庭	formal presence
place X before a board	提交 X 審議	formal submission

For your original sentence

> ****Before meeting him****, I used to think studying meant memorising facts and repeating them in exams.

Here:

****before = 在.....之前****

and:

****before meeting him = 在認識他之前****

The phrase sets up a clear contrast:

****before meeting Mr Chan****

→ learning = memorising facts

****after learning from Mr Chan****

→ learning = asking questions, considering different angles, thinking independently

A natural Traditional Chinese rendering is:

> ****在認識他之前****，我一直以為讀書就是背誦資料，然後在考試中重複寫出來。

For this passage, it is the straightforward ****temporal “earlier than an event”**** sense of ****before****.